universally condemned. Logic and rationality dictated that India too should have denounced the invasion. Strategically, India would have benefited from offering support to Kuwait though it also needed to protect 170,000 Indians working and living in Iraq and Kuwait.

Under Gujral's influence, V.P. Singh's coalition government appeared flummoxed and unsure of what to do. India chose to be neutral in the ensuing conflict, ignoring that one non-aligned member country had invaded another. Soon after the invasion of Kuwait, Gujral went to Baghdad and instead of conveying India's concerns about Saddam's actions ended up creating the perception of sympathy for Saddam Hussein. The government did succeed, however, in evacuating 110,000 Indian citizens from Iraq and Kuwait, leaving behind only those who chose to stay there through the war.

India's response to the Gulf War of 1991 had several consequences. Saddam Hussein's military was badly defeated and the Kuwaiti royal family was restored to power. While Saddam was in no position to advance any economic or political interest of India, the V.P. Singh government's neutrality cost India the goodwill of Kuwait and the Gulf Arab countries. Saudi Arabia and other Gulf Arab states reduced employment opportunities for Indians and showed their displeasure by withholding investment and job contracts. It took decades for India to overcome this setback. For an administration that lasted less than a year, the V.P. Singh government cast a long shadow on Indian foreign policy, especially in the Gulf Arab region.

V.P. Singh's short-lived government was followed by one for eight months headed by Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar (November 1990–June 1991). Chandra Shekhar had been in politics a long time and had a good understanding of both domestic and global issues. Presiding over a weak coalition government, he still managed to make major decisions. One such decision was to allow refuelling facility to US aircraft during the Gulf War, which served as some mitigation for the V.P. Singh government's errors.